



Dominican Republic

The Dominican Republic occupies the eastern two-thirds of the island of Hispaniola in the Caribbean. Spanish-speaking, it seeks closer ties to the anglophone West Indies.



GEOGRAPHY

Highlands and rainforested mountains – including the highest peak in the Caribbean, Pico Duarte – interspersed with fertile valleys. Extensive coastal plain in the east.



CLIMATE

Hot and humid close to sea level, cooler at altitude. Heavy rainfall, especially in the northeast.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

White landowners – especially those descended from the original Spanish settlers – form the wealthy elite. Mixed-race majority controls commerce and forms the bulk of the professional middle classes. White and mixed-race women are entering the professions. Great disparities of wealth exist; the black and Haitian-immigrant populations occupy the bottom of the social ladder.



THE ECONOMY

Mining (nickel and gold), sugar, and textiles. Tourism, remittances, and exports all rely heavily on US market. Hidden economy based on transshipment of narcotics to the US.



INSIGHT: *Santo Domingo is the oldest city in the Americas. It was founded in 1496 by the brother of Christopher Columbus*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Dominican Republic

DATE OF FORMATION: 1865

CAPITAL: Santo Domingo

POPULATION: 10.1 million

TOTAL AREA: 18,679 sq. miles
(48,380 sq. km)

DENSITY: 540 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Spanish*, French Creole

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 92%, other and nonreligious 8%

ETHNIC MIX: Mixed race 75%, White 15%, Black 10%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Dominican Republic peso
= 100 centavos